

Chapter 4: First Mother of the Uninvited

Mara stared at her own face carved in stone.

The statue in the floating image was old and rain-worn, its nose broken, one hand missing. But the face was still hers.

Not exactly.

The eyes were colder. The mouth calmer. The jaw harder than Mara remembered seeing in any mirror.

Beneath it, Eliya's language glowed.

Mara Venn.

First Mother of the Uninvited.

Eliya's fear sharpened.

What did you do to my family?

"I don't know," Mara whispered.

Kael looked at her. "That answer is becoming less useful."

"It's still true."

The black-glass chamber reflected nothing. Above the crescent table, the Sol family file hovered in layers: portraits, bloodlines, memory fragments, broken legal seals bleeding red light.

Eliya wanted to reach it.

Mara felt the pull before she understood it.

Those are private.

"I know."

No, you don't.

Eliya pushed.

The body took half a step before the restraints flashed, locking their wrists in place.

Kael lifted a hand. "Do not force movement."

“She wants to see her family,” Mara said.

“She is in no condition to process the file.”

“It is my file,” Eliya snapped.

The voice was hers.

Fully hers.

Mara felt herself shoved backward, deeper into the body. For one strange second, she became the passenger. The watcher behind Eliya’s eyes.

Eliya looked down at the restraints.

“Remove them.”

Kael’s expression tightened. “Eliya—”

“Remove them.”

“You are under protective seizure.”

“Then protect me from her, not from my own hands.”

The words struck Mara harder than expected.

Kael held Eliya’s gaze, then nodded.

The restraints vanished.

Mara felt the wrists return.

Eliya felt them first.

The woman with the glass ring stepped closer. “Control balance is unstable.”

“I know,” Eliya said.

“If the intruder attempts override—”

“She won’t.”

Mara went still inside her.

Eliya had not said it kindly.

But she had said it.

Kael watched them both. “Can you guarantee that?”

“No,” Eliya said. “But I can feel when she lies.”

Eliya walked to the table.

This time, Mara did not try to move.

The Sol family line unfolded in threads of light. Faces appeared: children, elders, scholars, soldiers, strangers Mara had never met but could feel through Eliya’s grief.

Eliya touched one image.

A man with warm eyes and gray at his temples.

Lyr Sol.

Her father.

A memory slipped through before Mara could stop it.

A hand guiding small fingers around a stylus.

A laughing voice: History is not dead, little star. It is only waiting for someone rude enough to wake it.

Eliya flinched.

Mara pulled back as hard as she could.

“I’m sorry.”

Then stay away from him.

“I’m trying.”

“You are not trying enough.”

The words were aloud.

Kael heard them.

Mara felt shame rise through a body that had no reason to offer it.

Eliya opened another record.

Her mother appeared.

Anet Varesh Sol.

Silver beads braided into dark hair. A severe mouth. Tired eyes.

The file marked her status in red.

Deceased.

Eliya touched the image.

“Anet Varesh Sol,” the archive said. “Date of death: sealed under Accord security statute.”

Eliya went cold.

“What statute?”

The archive did not answer.

Kael stepped closer. “Eliya.”

She turned on him. “What statute?”

Kael said nothing.

The woman with the glass ring looked away.

Eliya understood.

So did Mara.

“My mother’s death was never a transit accident,” Eliya said.

Kael’s silence was worse than confirmation.

The archive shifted again.

Mara’s statue returned, larger now. Beside it, a historical entry appeared.

Kael read it aloud.

“First Mother of the Uninvited. Mythic designation attached to early Earth-origin intrusion events. Associated with unauthorized bloodline mapping, host conversion, and the founding schism of the Sol line.”

Mara stared at him.

“Host conversion?”

The woman with the ring answered. “When a host stops being legally recognized as one person.”

Eliya's hand tightened on the table.

Mara felt her fear.

Not fear of death.

Fear of becoming shared forever.

"No," Mara said. "I would never do that."

Kael looked exhausted.

"Someone with your name did."

"That is impossible."

"In your era, maybe."

The archive flashed.

A new file opened without anyone touching it.

Static filled the room.

Then breathing.

Then a man's voice.

"Mara, if this reaches you, do not trust Vale."

Mara stopped.

The voice was older than she remembered, rougher and broken by distance.

But she knew it.

Her father.

Jonas Venn.

The missing pioneer.

Mara surged forward so hard Eliya staggered.

"No," Eliya snapped.

"That's my father."

"And this is my body."

“Please.”

The word came out small.

Not command.

Not apology.

A plea.

For one breath, neither of them fought.

Then Eliya lifted their hand and touched the recording.

Jonas Venn’s face appeared above the table.

Older. Thinner. One eye clouded white. Behind him, something burned in a dark sky.

“Mara,” he said, “you are not the first because they failed before you. You are the first because they erased the others.”

Mara could not breathe.

“The Gate does not send awareness to strangers. It follows descendants. Bloodlines. Echoes. They called compatibility a safety measure. It is not. It is a map.”

Kael’s face hardened.

The woman whispered, “This file was not here before.”

Jonas leaned closer.

“If you wake inside Eliya Sol, listen carefully.”

Eliya’s name hit the room like glass breaking.

“She is not your destination. She is the lock.”

The recording flickered.

Mara stepped forward.

“What does that mean?”

Jonas could not hear her.

“They will tell you the future hates Earth. They will tell Eliya that Earth made her family suffer. Both are true. But not the whole truth.”

Kael moved toward the table. “Stop playback.”

The archive ignored him.

Jonas’s voice dropped.

“The first intrusion did not come from Earth.”

The chamber went silent.

Jonas looked directly at Mara.

“It came from here.”

The image cut out.

Every light in the chamber turned red.

“Unauthorized memory release detected,” the archive announced. “Containment breach in Archive District Seven.”

Kael swore.

The woman grabbed Eliya’s arm. “We have to move.”

Eliya pulled back. “My family file—”

“It was bait,” Kael said.

The chamber doors sealed.

Something struck them from the other side.

Once.

Twice.

Then a voice spoke through the wall.

Calm.

Familiar.

Impossible.

“Mara,” Dr. Soren Vale said. “Step away from the Accord officers.”

Mara’s blood turned cold.

Eliya whispered inside their shared skull.

You said he was on Earth.

Mara stared at the sealed door.

“He was.”

DaintyHub